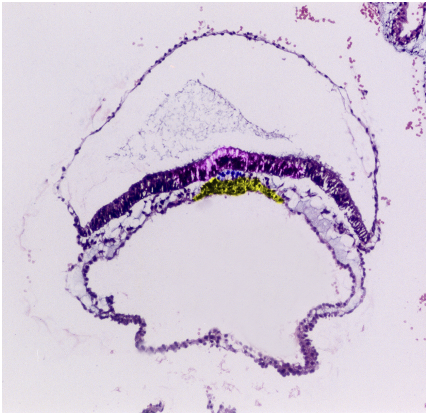




YOU ARE **4 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

250 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

The embryo until this stage of development has consisted of two layers of cells. Now, a third layer starts to become visible as a “bulge” between the two—this bulge can be seen in the center of this image.

“In this third week since conception, the cells that will become the embryo move to form the basis of the central nervous system.”

While you're busy coming to terms with being pregnant, there are incredible changes taking place inside you. The group of cells, that will become your baby is currently shaped as a flat disk and undergoing significant development. A narrow groove begins to form down the middle of the cells. The leading edge of the groove is slightly wider, forming a circular “node.” The outer edges of the node and groove are slightly raised. The cells move from the rolled edges of these structures downward into the groove to lie between the original two layers of cells. This creates three layers of cells, those on each outer disk surface and those sandwiched between them. The node and groove do not extend along the entire length of the disk.

At the head end, a separate groove forms. Called the neural groove, this ultimately forms the brain and spinal cord (the central nervous system). In four days' time, the disk will lengthen and widen at the end that will form your baby's head. In six days' time, the neural groove has folds on either side that will later meet to form the neural tube.